

Lack of knowledge

Globally, and in India, companies don't have the resources to manage intellectual property or understand the makeup of the software. A few bigger companies may have the resources but not the knowledge. "Source Code Control can help these companies achieve a quicker time to market because it can help them manage these problems. It can help them give their customers the software BoM — the licences in their code," says Callinan.

Mid-sized tech companies are looking to grow their businesses and seek investments. Source Code Control helps these companies get investor-ready, by ensuring software quality before they meet the investor.

In India, Source Code Control is associated with NASSCOM, as well as with investors and tech communities to help them get an understanding of the open source software challenge.

Callinan says, "I used to work for Microsoft in the UK around licence compliance. The reason why companies became non-compliant with Microsoft technology is because they didn't have the knowledge to track where the software was installed and where the licence was purchased. I worked through this journey of creating processes and helping educate customers how to manage compliance."

"Around 2008, I started looking at open source. Back then, it was not very popular. It was only when mobile devices started dominating the market that the whole technology stack opened up. Developers started using open source and sharing code on the Internet. But they are not business people. Nobody was looking at the business risks of the decisions made by the developers to take outdated code off the Internet and bring it to an application."

"We started this business in 2014 to take the learnings of what happened in managing the compliance

at Microsoft and applying it to open source in software developments. When we started, there was no guidance, there was no best practice, no standards to help customers manage that problem. We started the journey to create those standards and define the processes. We got involved with the OpenChain initiative run by the Linux Foundation. It is supported by big tech companies that have come together to figure out how to manage the business risks in the software supply chain. It is now an ISO standard," he says.

Source Code Control is a partner-friendly organisation looking to develop partnerships with Indian companies ranging from big consultancies to independent software vendors. It is also partnering with GitHub to educate companies with respect to software risks.

Hiring in India

There is a lot of talent in India with knowledge of IP, code and the security issues. Source Code Control has hired ten people in India so far. It is looking for people who have a good understanding of the IP and software development process, particularly relating to the code and open source licensing. A lot of work that is done is data related, hence several data analysts will be needed as the business grows. Graduates are also being recruited whilst building their knowledge.

Many companies from the US and UK outsource software development to India. However, the disconnect between the developers and the business management in a company in India can lead to a major business risk. Source Code Control acts like an interface between the management and developers in a crowded competitive market. Companies that can provide a software BoM have a commercial edge and this also helps mitigate future business risks.

Insurance companies have to consider the worst case situation to quantify the risk due to security breaches. If the company is able to demonstrate that a process for tracking vulnerabilities and managing IP is present in the code, the insurance premiums could be less, leading to a commercial advantage and business benefit.

Licensing models

The evolution of open source is being driven by the changes in technology. Due to Covid-19, many companies in India are moving to the cloud. Two major cloud service providers are AWS and Microsoft Azure, which are in no way more ethical than other service providers in this domain.

It is a commercial strategy of software companies to offer free versions of their technology under an open source licence (example, MongoDB or Elasticsearch). As companies grow bigger, they purchase the commercial licence later. But since AWS has made it so easy to get a free version, many open source companies have had to change or modify the licences of their free software. Elasticsearch recently changed its licensing model and made it mandatory to purchase a commercial licence. It said that in case the free version is used, the source code of everything that is developed has to be revealed, which is not feasible for companies.

The way hackers operate is changing as well. They are putting malware into the code, which is being downloaded by developers into their application and then shipped. Hence when the software is delivered to the customer, hackers can exploit the malware.

Source Code Control can help companies understand and manage these attacks. As technologies evolve, the licensing models will change, which can accelerate commercial risks. Continuous management of the code being developed is what is required. **END** 